

The Epistemology of the Author of the Pātañjalayogaśāstra-vivaraṇa

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Introduction

Pramāṇa—valid means of knowledge—in the following context, is one of the most widely discussed topics in philosophical Sanskrit writings. In other words, we may consider a Sanskrit text as philosophical if it contains a discussion on *pramāṇa*.¹

In the Pātañjalayogaśāstra (PYŚ)—the term we give to the combination of the so-called Yogasūtra and the so-called Yogabhāṣya—*sūtra* 1.6 lists the five *cittavṛttis*: *pramāṇa*, *viparyaya*, *vikalpa*, *nidrā*, and *smṛti*. What are accepted as *pramāṇa* are listed in the next *sūtra*. They are: *pratyakṣa*, *anumāna* and *āgama*. There are no *sūtras* dedicated to define each of them but definitions are given in the Bhāṣya. This inclusion of the discussion on *pramāṇa* is probably one of the reasons why we consider the PYŚ to be a philosophical work. And I speculate the same was the case with the contemporaneous intellectuals of South and Southeast Asia whose literal language included the Sanskrit language.

There is a commentary (Vivaraṇa) on the PYŚ, or a sub-commentary on the Yogabhāṣya, ascribed to Śaṅkara. We call it the Pātañjalayogaśāstravivaraṇa based on the first prose sentence of the text even though I do not believe that its author had any specific title in mind.² A characteristic of this (sub)commentary is that it often dedicates substantial amount of text to discuss certain issues that its author considered important. The discussion on *pramāṇa* is relatively brief in the *sūtra* (it only lists names; see above) and the Bhāṣya but it is one of the topics the author of the Vivaraṇa thought was important. He dedicates much effort expounding his views on various issues surrounding *pramāṇa*. Essentially, his goal is to explain and defend the *sūtra* and the Bhāṣya but occasionally we get glimpses of his own philosophy. This paper aims at demonstrating two things: one is to illustrate the difficult text critical situation that a reader of the Vivaraṇa faces; and the other is to shed light on a unique thought the author

¹ That is not to say that a text that does not contain discussions on *pramāṇa* is not a philosophical work. In other words, we may consider a text philosophical even when there is not dedicated discussions on *pramāṇa*, for example, the Vākyapadīya of Bhartṛhari.

² See Harimoto 2014, p. 9.

of the Vivaraṇa had. This philosophy is surprisingly close to that of Śaṅkara, the author of the Brahmasūtrabhāṣya.

The Text that the Vivaraṇa Interprets

The text of the Bhāṣya on *pratyakṣa* appears simple enough.³ The author of the Vivaraṇa cleverly weaves his own thoughts on *pramāṇa* while maintaining the structure of the commentary as that of the root text.⁴

Pratyakṣa and Viśeṣa

The first issue our author apparently felt the need of addressing was the domain of *pratyakṣa*: whether it is *viśeṣa* (only) or not. Also, he felt the need to counter the position of the Buddhist that *sāmānya* is unreal. For these two points, he give the answers

- that there is a reason why the Bhāṣya says that *pratyakṣa* is mainly concerned with determining specifics (*viśeṣāvadhāraṇapradhāna*)
- and that sense faculties do obtain *sāmānya*, too

These points, especially the latter offers interesting material as a response to the famous position Buddhist maintained but an analysis of this part—albeit short—will be done at some other occasion. We will move forward in the meantime.

Yogipratyakṣa and Mānasapratyakṣa

The next question that the author of the Vivaraṇa deals with is the position of the yogins' cognition and internal sensations. Some may apply terms such as *yogipratyakṣa* and *mānasapratyakṣa* respectively to those concepts. The terms are not used in the Vivaraṇa but

³ *indriyapraṇāḍīkayā cittasya bāhyavastūparāgāt tadviṣayā sāmānyaviśeṣātmano 'rthasya viśeṣāvadhāraṇapradhānā vṛttiḥ pratyakṣam pramāṇam phalam tadaviśiṣṭaḥ pauruṣeyaś cittavṛttibodhaḥ pratisaṃvedī puruṣa ity upariṣṭāt pravedayiṣyāmaḥ*

⁴ For general introduction to the text critical situation and the relationship between witnesses of the Vivaraṇa, see Harimoto 2014, pp. 15–43. A few things are worth noting here: First, There are only two key witnesses to the text. Both are palm-leaf manuscripts written in the Malayalam script. One is from Trivandrum and the other is preserved in Lahore. The remaining witnesses all derive from either of the two palm-leaf manuscripts. This includes the 1952 edition. The partial edition distributed as a handout for this paper differs from the critical edition in Harimoto 2014 in the following aspects: It uses roman script; It mentions only three witnesses (a palm-leaf manuscript in Trivandrum, another in Lahore and the edition published in 1952).

certainly the author was aware of the rich discussion surrounding these two. The problem for him was that neither the sūtra nor the Bhāṣya refers to those concepts and even bigger was the fact that the Bhāṣya used the word *indriyapranāḍikayā* in the definition of *pratyakṣa*. If one applies this characterization as a condition for a cognition to fall into *pratyakṣa*, then *yogipratyakṣa* and *mānasapratyakṣa* fail. The author of the Vivaraṇa tries to solve these two well-known categories failing to be accounted for in the Pātañjala system.

His solution to this problem is apparently that they still belong to *pratyakṣa*. The reason why I say apparently is because the paragraph that provides the answer has serious textual problems. This is a good place to introduce the state of the text transmission of the Vivaraṇa.

[See section 1.3.2 of the edition]

In my text, the answer starts with “*ucyate — na pramāṇāntaraml pratyakṣasya puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena parihṛtatvāt.*” However, the readings from all the available witnesses clearly derived from the text “*ucyate na pramāṇasya puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena parihṛtatvāt.*” This is also the reading that the edition princeps published in 1952 in Madras had. This is unintelligible. In this case, there are several reasons we can point out why this text does not make sense. Firstly, the question was whether the two kinds of cognitions were other kinds of *pramāṇa* or *pratyakṣa*. Answering to the question “Is A B or C?” with the answer “No” would be a funny joke but it is not a real answer. Another reason why the text transmitted in our manuscripts is clearly wrong is the word *puruṣapratyayāpekṣatva* used in the answer. This is one of expressions our author uses, being inspired by the sentence in the Bhāṣya: *phalaṃ tadaviśiṣṭaḥ pauraṣeyaś cittavṛttibodhaḥ* that he quotes immediately after. Our author appears to take this sentence as the true definition of *pratyakṣa* as implied in the next paragraph.⁵ There the expression is *tadaviśiṣṭapuruṣapratyayaphalāvasānatvāt pratyakṣatā siddhaiva*. In other words, resulting in the effect that is a notion belonging to *puruṣa* but not distinguished from the activity (*tad* refers to *vṛtti*) is *pratyakṣa*, according to our author. Hence, in the beginning of the answer section, too, the phrase *puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena* should be about *pratyakṣa*, not *pramāṇa* as the manuscripts and the editio princeps read. The quality of anticipating a notion belonging to *puruṣa* belongs to *pratyakṣa*. With my emendation, the first part of the answer should be understood as “No. For, as *pratyakṣa* presupposes notions belonging to *puruṣa*, [that those cognitions forming another] is precluded.”

There may be other possibilities of emendation but the point the author should be pushing forward is that those two cognitions are still *pratyakṣa* because they generate a notion on *puruṣa*’s side. This understanding of what constitute *pratyakṣa* appears unique. I have not found anything like this being discussed in the context of definition of *pratyakṣa*.

I am also impressed by the way the author incorporated the rather innocuous looking text of the Bhāṣya in his argument.

⁵ *evaṃ ca sati sukharāgādijñānasya kliṣṭākliṣṭarūpasya tadaviśiṣṭapuruṣapratyayaphalāvasānatvāt pratyakṣatā siddhaivall* (That being the case, it is very much established that the cognition of pleasure, wish, etc., which can be either wholesome or not wholesome, is *pratyakṣa* since it ends up with the effect that is the notion belonging to *puruṣa* but not distinguished from it [the cognition].)

Pramāṇaphala

And this giving much significance to the one piece of Bhāṣya text continues in the form of the discussion on *pramāṇaphala*. As seen in the handout, practically all the rest of the text on *pratyakṣa* is in fact a discussion on *pramāṇaphala* (anything under the section number 1.4). This is still part of an explanation of the short sentence in the Bhāṣya.

I cannot confidently say that I fully understand the text we have or whether the text we have more or less represents what the author meant. There will be a need for more thinking and revisions of the text.

Still, I am somewhat confident of the structure of the discussion and positions our author maintains:

- There is no independent *pramāṇaphala*
- Nor *pramāṇa* itself is its *phala*
- Either action [resulting from *pramāṇa*] or a state of *dravya* [the *pramāṇa* causes man to seek] is mutually figuratively the *phala*(?)
- *Pramāṇa* does not lead to *mokṣa*
- The Naiyāyika definition of *pratyakṣa* is wrong
- The view that the *phala* is one of the desire to take, to remove/avoid, or being impartial is wrong
- *Puruṣa* is aware of *cittavṛtti* as the revealer (*abhivyañjaka*)
- *Puruṣa*'s being aware of *cittavṛtti* is itself not *pratyakṣa*

Each of these points is interesting and worth examining; some of these are not run of the mill philosophical views but unique ones. Finding out where these views come from, against whom our author is arguing, and so forth, should help us better appreciate the author of the Vivaraṇa as a philosopher.

Distrust of *Pramāṇa*

In the meantime, however, I will focus on one point: our author's distrust of *pramāṇa*. This was the 4th point above and corresponds to section 1.4.3.4 including subtopics there. Especially interesting are the subsections 1.4.3.4.1 to 1.4.3.4.6 where our author has a conversation with a hypothetical opponent. Our author concedes that the main primary result of *pramāṇa* belongs to *puruṣa* in its mistaken state (*mithyābhūtasyaiva mukhyaphalatvaṃ vṛtyākārasya*), and that experience (*bhoga*) accompanied by activities of mind (*cittavṛtti*) is nothing but wrong (*mithyābhūta eva vṛtyanugato bhogaḥ*). And finally those who think *pramāṇaphala* is not mistaken will not have *mokṣa* (*yeṣāṃ amithyā phalam teṣāṃ...mokṣābhāvaḥ*). This last point should raise some eyebrows. It sounds quite peculiar.

However, there is a very famous person who also thought *pramāṇa* not to be conducive to the final goal. He also talked ill of *pramāṇa* and those who give much importance to it. It is Śaṅkara

the author of the Brahmasūtraśāṅkarabhāṣya. In the curious beginning of the commentary,⁶ he tells us how *pramāṇas* and *śāstras* (obviously he means *pratyakṣa* and *anumāna* as *pramāṇa* and *śāstra* as independent) have the domain that come from *avidyā*:

katham punar avidyāvadviṣayāṇi pratyakṣādīni pramāṇāni śāstrāṇi cetil

*ucyate---dehendriyādiṣv ahaṁmamābhimānarahitasya pramāṭṛtvānupapattau
pramāṇapravṛtṭyanupapatteḥl nahīndriyāṇy anupādāya pratyakṣādivyavahāraḥ
saṁbhavatil na cādhiṣṭhānam antareṇendriyāṇāṁ vyavahāraḥ saṁbhavatil na
cānādhyastātmabhāvena dehena kaścid vyāpriyatel na caitasmin sarvasminn asati
asaṅgasyātmanah pramāṭṛtvam upapadyatel na ca pramāṭṛtvam antareṇa
pramāṇapravṛtṭtir astil tasmād avidyāvadviṣayāṇy eva pratyakṣādīni pramāṇāni śāstrāṇi
cal*

*paśvādibhiś cāviśeṣātl yathā hi paśvādayaḥ śabdādibhiḥ śrotrādīnāṁ saṁbandhe sati,
śabdādivijñāne pratikūle jāte tato nivartante, anukūle ca pravartante; yathā
daṇḍodyatakaraṁ puruṣam abhimukham upalabhya māṁ hantum ayam icchatīti
palāyitum ārabhante, haritatṛṇapūrṇapāṇim upalabhya taṁ praty abhimukhībhavanti;
evam puruṣā api vyutpannacittāḥ krūrādiṣṭīn ākrośataḥ khaḍgodyatakarān balavata
upalabhya tato nivartante, tadviparītān prati pravartante, ataḥ samānaḥ paśvādibhiḥ
puruṣāṇāṁ pramāṇaprameyavyavahāraḥl paśvādīnāṁ ca prasiddho
'vivekapuraḥsaraḥ pratyakṣādivyavahāraḥ, tatsāmānyadarśanād vyutpattimatām api
puruṣāṇāṁ pratyakṣādivyavahāras tatkālaḥ samāna iti niścīyatel (BSSBh NSP ed pp.
40–43)*

What this section essentially does is to explain why *pramāṇas* and *śāstras* have the domain that come from *avidyā*. The first part of the answer explains why *pramāṇa* is possible only when there is the misidentification of what is not “I” or “mine” as “I” or “mine.” He appears to be talking how the action (*pravṛtti*) of the verb *pramā-* is not possible from the *kāraka* (*karaṇa*, *adhikaraṇa*?, *karṭṛ*, at least) point of view in that paragraph.

The second paragraph is amusing. Śāṅkara likens the educated people to animals. What Śāṅkara has in mind is this idea that *pramāṇa* eventually results in *pravṛtti* (taking action) or *nivṛtti* (stopping action). And that is not desirable from his well-known standpoint of no-action.

Final Remarks

Let me go back to the title of this paper: the epistemology of the author of the Pātañjalayogaśāstravivaraṇa. He spends quite a bit of space discussing *pramāṇa*, if we may identify the concept of *pramāṇa* and that of epistemology. The total length of the text he spends would be at least as twice as long as the distributed handout. Yet he is sceptical of the utility of *pramāṇa* when it comes to *mokṣa* as we have seen above. This, I think, is a noteworthy

6 The beginning of the commentary does not conform to the norm. It abruptly starts with *yuṣmadasmatpratyayagocarayor* without any indication of a start of a work. And this was the beginning known to the commentators of the work. The real beginning that conforms to the format other commentaries ascribed to the same author is found later at *vedāntamīmāṃsāśāstrasya vyācikhyāsitasyedam ādimam sūtram—*.

philosophy of the author. On the other hand, Śaṅkara's lack of interest regarding *pramāṇa*, despite the time period he lived, has been noted. Nowhere in the *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* declares he how many *pramāṇas* he accepts or what sort of definition of *pramāṇa* he follows. I always found that portion where Śaṅkara likens those "educated" people to animals to be fascinating. I thought that place explained why he did not participate in the game of *pramāṇa*; he did not believe in *pramāṇa*.⁷ Now, we have this text where the author exhibits quite a bit of knowledge on *pramāṇa*. He is even ready to criticize the Buddhist position. It is tempting to think that this text, the *Vivaraṇa*, supplies us of the information as to what Śaṅkara knew about and thought of *pramāṇa*. If we read the *Vivaraṇa*, it appears to give background information about the passage about *pramāṇa* and being like animals. The sarcastic passage in the *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* and the following sarcastic conclusion to the discussion on *pramāṇaphala* just read like from the same sense of humor to me:

tasmāt pramāṇaphalābhijñānābhīmānamātram eva kevalam paṇḍitammanyānām ity upekṣaṇīyam itill

(In conclusion, just a pure arrogant misconception about the term *pramāṇaphala* simply belongs to those who mistakenly consider themselves to be learned; it should simply be ignored.)

Well, it appears that was exactly what Śaṅkara did in the *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya*.

Select Bibliography

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⁷ Obviously such a statement demands clarifications because Śaṅkara spends much effort arguing that knowledge leads to salvation and it comes from Upaniṣads. A reconciliation between the distrust of *pramāṇa* in general and his belief in Upaniṣads should be found but that will be at another opportunity.